is in harmony with the accumulated ***karma*** of individuals. When *Shiva* decides that a soul's ***mala*** has matured, he will move him to seek initiation, which induces the destruction of ***mala***. The soul will be released at death, when the effects of its past ***karma*** have been exhausted.

Further reading: Cowell and Gough 1996; Filliozat 1994; Goodall 1998; Goudriaan 1992; Sanderson 1992

Shakti: power, especially that of a masculine god when personified as his female partner. Thus the goddess *Lakshmi* is the *Shakti* of *Vishnu*.

Shankara (c. 700 CE): renouncer and major theorist of nondualistic ***Advaita Vedanta***. He wrote commentaries on the ***Brahma-sutras*** that summarise the ideas of the major ***Upanishads***, and the ***Bhagavad Gita***. The *Upadesasahashri* ('Thousand Teachings') is also an important work.

Like all *Vedantins*, he held that transpersonal scripture (***shruti***) is the only means of knowledge (***pramana***) about whatever lies beyond the empirical world. And it is as an interpreter demonstrating the conformity of his beliefs with the *Upanishadic* texts that he may best be understood.

He thinks that the Absolute Reality (***Brahman***) is undifferentiated, relationless, static, contentless consciousness and bliss. It is beyond all oppositions such as that of knower and known. But due to primal ignorance (***avidya***) it somehow becomes the substratum of diversity. The self-evident conscious soul (***atman***), which is the constant witness (*sakshin*) of all mental states, is identical with ***Brahman***.

Differentiation and action, albeit experienced, are ultimately unreal. All plurality of selves, mental events, objects, causes and effects is a function of beginningless ignorance generating the misapprehension of the self as a